

The Weekly Digest

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THE WORLD THIS WEEK

Politics

America launched self-defense strikes against Iran following the downing of an Apache helicopter, leading to Iranian retaliation against U.S. bases and other Middle Eastern sites. This escalation occurred after Israel also bombed Iran, responding to earlier missile attacks that followed Israeli strikes on Hizbullah in Beirut. Meanwhile, a Palestinian baby's funeral was held after being killed by an Israeli soldier in the West Bank, prompting an investigation. Globally, over 100 people died from Ebola in the Democratic Republic of Congo, while protests erupted in Kenya against an Ebola quarantine center. Somalia's capital, Mogadishu, experienced its worst political violence in years amid

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fighting over President Mohamud's expired term, and South Africa saw increased migrant repatriations due to anti-immigrant violence. In other news, a Sudanese migrant's knife attack in Belfast sparked anti-migrant riots across Northern Ireland and other parts of Britain, while John Healey resigned as Britain's defense secretary over military spending. Armenia's general election returned the ruling party, boosting ties with the West despite Russian interference, and major earthquakes hit the Philippines and Cuba. Afghanistan saw rare protests against Taliban hijab directives, and Pakistan carried out new air strikes on Afghanistan. Xi Jinping visited North Korea, emphasizing strengthening ties, and Peru's presidential election result was too close to call. Lastly, Donald Trump nominated Todd Blanche as attorney-general, a federal judge overturned a policy on H-1B visa fees, and San Francisco voters rejected a tax increase on highly paid executives.

Business

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OpenAI filed a draft prospectus for its IPO, potentially targeting a \$1trn valuation, as Anthropic also prepared for its market debut and SpaceX geared up for its first share sale. Despite this IPO euphoria, stock markets had a rocky week, with NASDAQ and S&P 500 experiencing significant drops, and South Korea's market being particularly volatile. SK Hynix, a Korean chipmaker, is reportedly planning to list shares in America. China's exports surged 19.4% in May, driven by demand for chips and a 39% rise in car exports, with BYD's boss predicting it will become the world's biggest carmaker within five years. The European Central Bank raised interest rates for the first time since 2023, citing inflationary concerns exacerbated by the Iran war, while America's annual inflation rate hit a three-year high of 4.2% in May, largely due to energy prices. The International Air Transport Association halved its global airline profit forecast to \$23bn due to soaring jet-fuel prices and disruptions from the Iran war. A bidding war erupted for Italy's Monte dei Paschi di Siena, with Intesa

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Sanpaolo making a higher offer to create a banking colossus. In France, a consortium agreed to buy SFR for ?20.4bn to reduce Altice's debt, pending regulatory approval. GSK made its largest acquisition, buying American biotech firm Nuvalent for \$10.6bn. Finally, a working paper from the National Bureau of Economic Research suggested smartphones, particularly the iPhone, could explain 33-52% of the decline in America's fertility rate, citing reduced personal interactions and increased access to contraception advice and pornography.

The weekly cartoon

No significant coverage this issue.

LEADERS

The World Cup paradox

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Global events like the World Cup still capture immense attention, yet entertainment culture is increasingly localizing rather than globalizing. Despite platforms like Spotify and Netflix offering worldwide content, audiences are shifting away from American content towards local alternatives, a trend defying previous predictions. This fragmentation is evident in music, where charts are becoming more local, and in video streaming, where North America's share of new commissions has significantly dropped as services produce more foreign-language shows. Even gaming, particularly mobile gaming, shows strong regional variations, with different titles dominating in different markets. Cheaper production and distribution costs, combined with the rise of a global middle class and algorithm-driven content discovery, enable profitable targeting of smaller, local niches. This shift implies a weakening of America's soft-power dominance, compelling other countries to fill the void and requiring governments to adapt to new dynamics of cultural

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influence.

Donald Trump?s least bad option in Iran

Despite Donald Trump's claims of Iran's defeat, the regime remains emboldened, retaliating to American and Israeli attacks and threatening global energy supplies through the Strait of Hormuz. Trump is caught in a bind, facing Iranian defiance, Israeli uncooperativeness in Lebanon, and domestic hawkish pressure for full-scale war. The war has strengthened hardliners in Iran, who seem willing to risk further conflict rather than accept Trump's peace terms. Israel complicates efforts by continuing attacks on Hizbullah in Lebanon, even against Trump's wishes, which pleases Tehran. While hawks in America demand attacks on Iran's oil infrastructure, this strategy is unlikely to work, and Trump is right to resist it. Global oil prices have remained relatively stable due to demand curbs, increased production, and tapped reserves, but this is unsustainable, especially with summer demand

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approaching, risking an "excruciating" energy crunch that could impact midterm elections. Therefore, Trump must accept a less-than-ideal deal with Iran to reopen the Strait and secure a ceasefire, deferring nuclear program negotiations, even if it is unstable and humiliating for America.

The Federal Reserve must soon give Donald Trump bad news

Kevin Warsh, the new Federal Reserve chairman, faces an ironic situation where his dovish stance, which secured his appointment by President Trump, is now at odds with economic realities. Since his appointment in January, the U.S. labor market has strengthened, and economic growth is robust, largely fueled by tax cuts and AI excitement. Annual inflation hit a three-year high of 4.2% in May, partly due to oil prices from the Iran war, making it difficult for the Fed to ignore. Warsh's previous arguments for lower rates, based on AI's deflationary potential, now seem shaky, as AI-related

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boom is actually stoking consumption and investment, potentially raising inflation and requiring higher interest rates according to economic theory and his colleagues. His idea of reducing bond holdings (quantitative tightening) while cutting rates is deemed ineffective, as its impact on long-term bond yields would be minimal and potentially contradictory to rate signals. Therefore, rate cuts are off the table for Warsh's first meeting, and he will likely have to deliver bad news to President Trump, with rate increases being a more probable policy move later this year.

For its own sake, China should change its growth model

China's manufacturers have achieved formidable global competitiveness in sophisticated industries, reflected in surging exports. This industrial dominance, while a source of pride and geopolitical leverage for leaders, has not translated into widespread economic benefits for its people, with consumer confidence and retail sales

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remaining low. Unlike past export booms, recent high-tech successes are less labor-intensive and geographically concentrated, failing to generate widespread job growth or alleviate regional disparities. Furthermore, local governments' heavy subsidies for emerging industries erode their financial stability and lead to over-investment, as seen with only 15 out of 129 EV brands expected to be viable by 2030. This growth model results in limp domestic spending, falling prices, and a cheap currency, which further boosts exports but allows policymakers to delay crucial measures to restore consumer confidence. For its own economic health, China needs to diversify its sources of demand rather than solely focusing on industrial dominance.

The best way to celebrate America at 250 is to get behind the wheel

As America approaches its semiquincentennial, a pervasive sense of dread about the country's future contrasts with objective measures showing robust

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economic growth, rising life expectancy, and pre-eminence in various tech and creative fields. This disconnect between data and public sentiment is the focus of The Economist's new six-part podcast series, a road trip across America inspired by Alexis de Tocqueville's "Democracy in America." The podcast reveals that focusing solely on politics leads to an overly gloomy view, as Americans often agree on much more in person than online, and that social media distorts perceptions of national problems. The solution suggested for a clearer understanding is personal experience through travel, or listening to the podcast, to encounter thoughtful and generous Americans for whom politics is often peripheral. The article concludes that despite fears, Tocqueville's observations about American democracy and its underlying stability still hold true, offering a reason for celebration.

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LETTERS

What can you learn from the Premier League?

Several letters discuss the Premier League. One reader argues that the Premier League model, with its foreign ownership, imported workforce, and hollowed-out domestic leadership, is not a strategy for national renewal but rather economic dependency. This letter also criticizes the league's self-regulation, citing lenient treatment for elite clubs like Chelsea compared to harsher penalties for lower-tier clubs, and suggests Germany's Bundesliga, with its fan ownership and domestic player quotas, as a better model for national football. Another letter highlights that the Premier League's success is rooted in common standards and protocols, like the Cambridge Rules of 1848, which fostered simplicity, trust, and openness. A third letter wittily defines the term "Spursy" as chronic hypertension

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from a severe lack of trophies despite endless potential, drawing a parallel to scurvy.

BY INVITATION

Silicon Valley needs to get God

Glen Weyl argues that Silicon Valley needs to reorient towards moral purpose, drawing on Pope Leo XIV's encyclical Magnifica Humanitas, which offers a path for technology and religion to coexist. He suggests that partnering with ancient traditions provides stability against policy uncertainty and helps legitimize AI, allowing for wider adoption and preventing social backlash. Geopolitically, devout countries in the Global South, unlike China's repressive tech systems, are unlikely to embrace "automated atheism," making religious liberty a potent, yet currently unused, American soft power instrument. Weyl's personal experience in

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Asia, where technology often guards cultural traditions, and the greater optimism about AI in devout Asian nations compared to the West, further support his argument. He concludes that Silicon Valley doesn't need to convert, but to recognize its own creed, adopt more open technology design, and build products for the underserved religious market segment, recognizing that no single tradition holds a monopoly on truth.

This may just be the last World Cup

The World Cup's status as a unifying global event is increasingly threatened by rising ethno-nationalism and institutional dysfunction, leading the authors to question if this could be its last iteration. While past tournaments like Russia 2018 and Qatar 2022 overcame boycott calls, "Trump's World Cup" faces unprecedented challenges, including a host nation engaged in an illegal war with a participant, travel bans affecting citizens of multiple teams, and a leader threatening co-hosts. These political complexities, coupled with exorbitant ticket prices and

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controversial immigration policies, are giving fans pause. The authors suggest that if problems materialize, underlying strains within FIFA could become irremediable. FIFA is already dysfunctional, marked by tension between Europe (money) and the rest of FIFA (political power), internal conflicts, and struggles in regional federations. The authors outline a hypothetical scenario involving a Spanish fan's death, leading to boycotts and a potential unraveling of FIFA, emphasizing that while such a collapse is not guaranteed, the current edition will highlight the tournament's excesses, and its future form and relevance are increasingly uncertain.

BRIEFING

Entertainment is being deglobalised

Entertainment is increasingly localizing globally, a

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surprising trend given the reach of streaming platforms. In Denmark, for example, local music now dominates streaming charts, a shift seen across Europe and Latin America, including countries like Brazil and Nigeria. This phenomenon is driven by digital technology's reduction of entry barriers for local artists, making niche genres profitable, and a shift towards local touring and cultivating "superfans." Algorithms also play a role, funneling listeners into deeper niches, sometimes favoring local preferences over global hits. Streaming services like Netflix are adapting by commissioning more hyper-local, foreign-language productions, recognizing that universal shows don't always resonate, and that authentic local content has the best chance of becoming a global hit. This strategy is leading to a decline in the consumption of American TV shows globally and a rise in local content viewership in many countries. User-generated content on platforms like YouTube also shows stubbornly local consumption patterns, even at a sub-national level. In gaming, while

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PC/console gaming remains somewhat globalized, mobile gaming, with its larger and more diverse audience, exhibits strong regional tastes, exemplified by games like "Free Fire" tailored to emerging markets' needs and cultures. Chinese gamemakers are also expanding globally but often adapt content to local target markets, reflecting a broader trend where global tech platforms facilitate local preferences despite making worldwide distribution easier.

BRITAIN

Britain's privatised utilities are a mess

Britain's privatized utilities, particularly water, are facing a severe crisis, exemplified by Northern Ireland Water's massive sewage spills and the prevalence of raw sewage in English waterways. Left-wing politicians, including the Green Party and potential Labour prime minister

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Andy Burnham, blame privatization for these issues and advocate for public ownership, a view supported by a majority of the public. However, the article argues that nationalization is a "dead end," citing the poor performance of publicly owned Northern Ireland Water as evidence. It contends that many supposed benefits of nationalization are overstated, transitional costs would be steep, and it would be a distraction from necessary reforms. While acknowledging some past regulatory failures that allowed firms to accrue debt and extract high returns, it suggests that improved oversight, not a change in ownership, is the solution. The core problem is underinvestment, for which regulators and governments share blame by rejecting infrastructure proposals. Funding new investment will require difficult trade-offs?higher bills, taxes, or cuts elsewhere?which nationalization won't fundamentally alter, ultimately requiring political courage to make hard choices.

Britain's rail nationalisation is going full

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steam ahead

Britain's Labour Party is proceeding with the renationalization of railways, with the government now controlling 53% of trips, promising improved services, simpler fares, and cleaner facilities under the new state operator, Great British Railways (GBR). Despite commuters' complaints, British trains are more punctual than German state-run ones, and the article argues that privatization wasn't a complete disaster, as rail journeys more than doubled since 1994-95. The main legitimate complaint is high fares, among Europe's highest, alongside significant government subsidies. However, nationalization is unlikely to solve funding issues, as private operators weren't making excessive profits and some were already taken into public ownership due to financial distress. While a single coordinating body like GBR could improve services, the article warns of potential costs, such as GBR becoming a powerful monopoly that prioritizes its own services over private entrants, hindering competition. Furthermore, state

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ownership won't tackle rising costs from unions or changing travel patterns that have reduced revenue, leading to sticky trade-offs between fare rises and service quality that public ownership cannot easily resolve.

A kids? social-media ban would be a bad parting gift from Keir Starmer

Britain is moving towards banning social media for children under 16, a policy accelerated by political calculation ahead of an anticipated by-election, with Prime Minister Keir Starmer seeking a "game-changer." The government plans to announce its response to a public consultation, likely including exemptions for messaging and educational apps. While Australia, Canada, and the EU are moving in similar directions, and a YouGov poll shows 76% of Brits support a ban, the article argues it would be a mistake. Social media offers benefits alongside harms, and Australia's ban has proven leaky. Some families affected by social-media-linked

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deaths oppose the ban, fearing dangerous content lurks outside major apps. The policy also creates mixed messaging, as Britain aims to be a tech and AI champion, but rhetoric from Labour figures like Andy Burnham and Wes Streeting sounds increasingly hostile to big tech, risking harm to the UK's position in the AI sector and causing diplomatic tension with the US. The policy exemplifies Starmer's "vanilla brand of populism," embracing easy solutions regardless of complications.

A frenzied knife attack by a refugee has put Northern Ireland on edge

A frenzied knife attack by a Sudanese refugee in Belfast on June 8th, captured on video, quickly escalated into destructive anti-migrant riots across Northern Ireland. Hardline loyalist paramilitaries used online posts to organize protests, enforcing business closures and leading to arson attacks on migrants' homes, cars, and businesses, reminiscent of the region's third consecutive

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year of anti-migrant violence. Nationalist leaders condemned the events as a "racist pogrom," while some unionist figures, like Jim Allister, emphasized understanding anti-migrant sentiment, criticizing the "importation of an alien culture." The accused, Hadi Alodid, was not an illegal immigrant, having traveled from the Republic of Ireland, which sparked suggestions for border immigration checks. The unrest continued, with a riot in Glengormley seeing police attacked with petrol bombs, and parents bringing young children to watch. The article suggests this pattern of disruption will likely recur, even if the immediate unrest fades.

A posh and peculiar British magazine is thriving

Country Life, a peculiar British magazine, thrives by consistently ignoring current events, instead focusing on an idealized vision of rural England, featuring grand houses and traditional country pursuits. Established in 1897, it has become an institution, read by royalty and

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satirized by novelists, with 40,000 weekly buyers despite breaking most publishing maxims. The magazine is known for its "posh porn" opening pages, showcasing grand houses and debutantes (the "Girls in Pearls"), some of whom have become prominent figures, including a queen. Critics call it "rural porn for the rich" and "laughably old-fashioned," with its focus on the Cotswolds and asparagus, but its editor Mark Hedges argues it covers rural problems seriously and reflects what "actually affects most people's lives." Despite Britain being a predominantly urban nation, the magazine taps into a deep cultural longing for a romanticized rural Elysium, offering a philosophical focus on nature and tradition.

Bagehot

British politics, especially on the right, is rapidly shifting towards extreme positions, with ideas once taboo, like capital punishment and mass deportations, now entering mainstream debate. The far-right Restore party, led by

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Rupert Lowe, leverages incidents like the Belfast knife attack to push for executions and "millions must go" policies, influencing Reform UK and even segments of the Conservatives. Nigel Farage of Reform, once hesitant about mass deportations, now champions them, warning of "civil disorder" if his policies aren't adopted. Even center-right figures like Kemi Badenoch evoke "civil war" rhetoric, albeit condemning violence. This shift is fueled by a perception among some on the right that the British public are "bastards" who don't care about being labeled racist, a belief challenged by the public's typical "I'm not racist, but" stance. Bagehot argues that these extreme proposals, such as the death penalty and mass deportations, often wilt under scrutiny, and that politicians pushing them are disconnected from voters' daily frustrations. The Labour Prime Minister, Keir Starmer, is criticized for his silence and fatalism in confronting this aggressive rightward lurch, allowing the right's low expectations of bigotry to dominate the airwaves.

EUROPE

A trade war between the EU and China seems inevitable

A trade war between the EU and China is increasingly seen as unavoidable due to surging Chinese exports, rising bankruptcies in Europe, and declining industrial production, exacerbated by Chinese subsidies. The EU's trade deficit with China has doubled since the pandemic, leading to significant job losses in Germany and sluggish growth across Europe. While some blame Europe's internal issues, the OECD found Chinese firms receive three to eight times more subsidies than their counterparts. The EU has begun retaliating with tariffs on EVs and steel, and banning Chinese medical devices from public procurement. Options for further action include using existing trade-defence tools more forcefully, developing stronger import barriers like an "overcapacity instrument," and complementing trade

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measures with industrial policy like "Buy European" mandates. China views these complaints as European weakness and is expected to respond with tailored but strong measures, potentially including export bans on crucial materials, though a full-scale trade war might be avoided. Europe's consensus on tough measures remains fragile, with countries like Germany fearing retaliation and Spain advocating for targeted responses, highlighting the need to reduce dependencies on China to make trade-defence instruments effective.

Why Turkey likes NATO again

Turkey, once critical of NATO, is now more invested in the alliance, driven by America's wars in Iran and Russia's invasion of Ukraine, with public support for NATO rising. The country has benefited from NATO air defenses and will host a summit and receive new Patriot air-defense systems from Germany, alongside a multinational corps headquarters. Relations with America have improved due to troop withdrawals from

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Syria and hints of F-35 jet sales. Other NATO members indulge Turkey's democratic backsliding to keep it onside, recognizing its significant military and strategic importance in the Black Sea and its growing defense industry. Should America's commitment to NATO wane, Turkey sees continued membership as a way to maintain a seat at the table, unlike its stalled EU accession. Despite improved relations, trust remains low due to past grievances and differing views on Russia. However, Turkey is cooling on Russia, recognizing its weakened position in the Black Sea and the Caucasus, with President Erdogan's reduced engagement with Putin signaling a strategic shift.

Ukraine is transplanting its industrial heart to the west

Ukraine is undertaking a massive industrial relocation, moving the metalworking and machine-tooling factories of Kramatorsk, a front-line city, to Perechyn in the Carpathian mountains, far from the war zone. This "New

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Kramatorsk" effort, known as "Shoulder to Shoulder," began in 2022 and has accelerated as Russian forces advance on Kramatorsk. The relocation involves building a vast industrial park with new factories, roads, housing, and educational facilities, moving over 3,500 skilled workers to the west. This initiative is a "proof of concept" for moving an entire industrial "ecosystem" and aims to prevent the loss of skilled engineers. While Perechyn benefits from new revenues and job opportunities, the relocation has caused some local resentment, with protests over the easterners being shielded from the draft and a recent Russian drone strike bringing the war's reality to the sleepy town. Despite the hostility, some locals acknowledge the benefits, though the easterners face challenges in explaining their plight to those untouched by the war's direct destruction.

Ukrainian strikes are inflicting pain deep inside Russia

Ukrainian "deep strikes" inside Russia have intensified

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and are proving more damaging than commonly perceived, according to analysis of 1,289 strikes over 100km from Ukraine's borders. The number of such strikes surged from 335 between 2022-2024 to 658 in 2025 alone, with over 800 projected for this year. Despite Russian efforts to hide ammunition, ports, oil depots, and refineries have been repeatedly hit. A model assessing Russian export revenues against Brent crude prices suggests a significant shortfall since June 2025, with revenues being 12% lower than expected by end-2025 and 34% lower in the first four months of 2026. While a strong rouble and sanctions also contribute, these strikes are clearly costing Russia billions of dollars.

Armenia's election is a setback for Vladimir Putin

Armenia's recent general election saw Prime Minister Nikol Pashinyan's Civil Contract party win nearly 50% of the vote, securing a majority, despite intense Russian

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pressure and economic blackmail. Russia had banned imports of Armenian goods, spread disinformation, and issued dire threats against Pashinyan's Western-leaning policies. The European Union countered Russia's economic moves by finding alternative buyers for Armenian goods and announcing a financial aid package. Western leaders, including Ursula von der Leyen, welcomed the result, seeing it as a vindication of Armenia's 2018 Velvet Revolution and a step towards regional prosperity. Opposition parties, led by pro-Russian figures, failed to resonate with voters, offering nationalism and a return to a failed partnership with Russia, while their claims of election meddling were dismissed by international observers. Pashinyan's victory is expected to reassure Turkey and Azerbaijan, advancing peace talks and normalization of relations, including infrastructure projects. Despite falling short of a two-thirds majority to amend the constitution for judicial reform and peace talks, the election marks a significant setback for Vladimir Putin's influence in the

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region, although Russia could still retaliate with economic measures.

Charlemagne

On June 11th, the war in Ukraine surpassed the length of the First World War, serving as a grim reminder that conflicts often defy initial expectations. This prolonged struggle, despite tentative Ukrainian gains and Russian losses, has not yet led to serious peace talks, with Vladimir Putin resisting calls from Western leaders. When an armistice does come, it will likely be a messy compromise, without the full defeat or reparations seen at Versailles, but it will necessitate a new European security architecture and credible guarantees for Ukraine. The lessons of Versailles, particularly the need for enforceable promises and avoiding resentment, are crucial for achieving a lasting peace. Europe is caught between mediating and being a party to the conflict, facing difficult choices, including potentially lifting sanctions on Russia and returning frozen assets. The

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article concludes that while the desire to see Putin humbled is strong, a pragmatic approach that eventually includes him as a peace partner will be necessary, despite the strong longing for retribution.

UNITED STATES

America's quintessential places are getting old, fast

America's suburbs, traditionally built for young families, are rapidly aging, mirroring the familiar trend in rural areas. Between 2000 and 2024, the number of elderly residents in suburban counties more than doubled, while the young child population stagnated or declined. This demographic shift has significant consequences for housing markets, schools, and local politics. Housing shortages are exacerbated by under-building, particularly of smaller homes suitable for older adults looking to

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downsize. Many older homeowners, often without mortgages and benefiting from tax breaks, are incentivized to stay put in large family homes, creating a generational traffic jam. This leads to falling elementary school enrollments and fiscal challenges, as older residents on fixed incomes are more resistant to tax increases needed for schools and services. The increased political participation of older homeowners who often oppose new housing construction creates a feedback loop, accelerating the aging of communities. Politicians are reluctant to address these "politically toxic" issues, but demographic change is now an undeniable reality for suburbia.

The ageing protesters trying to topple Washington's ego arch?

Boomers, exemplified by Susan Douglas, are forming the backbone of resistance against Donald Trump's plans to build a 250-foot "ego arch" in Washington, D.C., ostensibly to commemorate America's

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semiquincentennial but widely seen as a monument to himself. Protesters, with a median age of 67, held a vigil near the proposed site and loudly opposed the project at a National Capital Planning Commission (NCPC) meeting. The arch's proposed location in Memorial Circle, obstructing the view between the Lincoln Memorial and Arlington Cemetery, is particularly contentious, as it disrupts a symbol of civil war reunification and disrespects the solemnity of honoring veterans. Trump bypasses congressional approval by citing a 1925 authorization for slender columns, but critics argue his arch is an entirely different scale and intent. Legal challenges, including a lawsuit by veterans, are likely to block the project, but the NCPC advanced the proposal. Douglas and her group remain resolute, plotting their next moves against what they view as a self-aggrandizing monument.

Should priests have to report child abuse disclosed in confession?

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The sanctity of confession, a core tenet of Catholicism, is being challenged in American state legislatures regarding the reporting of child abuse. While many states mandate professionals like teachers and doctors to report abuse, clergy exemptions for confessions create a "patchwork" of laws. Recent bills in Missouri and Vermont, though ultimately failing, sought to remove this exemption, forcing priests to choose between canon law (absolute seal of confession) and civil law. Religious-liberty lawyers argue such mandates violate the First Amendment, especially if other professions like lawyers retain similar privileges. Child-safety advocates, however, deem the confessional a potential place for uncovering undetected crimes and criticize the church's past mishandling of abuse reports, arguing the state has an overriding interest in protecting children. Victims also highlight how confessions can reveal abuse the child internalized as their own sin. Despite the recent legislative defeats, advocates believe the issue will continue to be debated.

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Social media is behind both ?teen takeovers? and the outrage they fuel

"Teen takeovers," where hundreds of young people converge for parties, are causing mayhem and political division in cities across America, including Chicago. These events, organized by anonymous "promoters" on social media platforms like TikTok, Instagram, and Snapchat, often lead to violence, such as shootings and assaults on police, as seen on Memorial Day weekend in Chicago. While many participants are just bored kids, their sudden mass gatherings frequently result in public disorder, raising concerns among city officials and fueling outrage, especially from conservative media and figures like Donald Trump. Managing these events is challenging for law enforcement, as it's difficult to disperse large crowds or predict where they will gather. The phenomenon highlights how social media can easily incite large-scale, disruptive youth gatherings, with some promoters even leveraging viral content for financial gain. Liberal city leaders like Chicago's Mayor Johnson

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face pressure to address the issue while avoiding harsh crackdowns, as public disorder remains a politically charged topic despite declining serious crime rates.

America's mayors join the scrabble to become influencers

American mayors are increasingly trying to become social media influencers to connect with constituents and promote their cities. At a recent Conference of Mayors in Long Beach, California, mayors discussed strategies for leveraging platforms like TikTok and Instagram. San Francisco Mayor Daniel Lurie, for example, prolifically posts videos showcasing local restaurants and city attractions to support businesses and rehabilitate his city's reputation. However, mayors face challenges such as avoiding accusations of favoritism towards businesses, navigating state laws restricting TikTok use on government devices, and dealing with negative public sentiment. Despite these concerns, many mayors, like Larry Klein of Sunnyvale, California, are enthusiastic

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about using social media, engaging in activities from food blogging to TikTok dances, believing it's an easy way to make a difference and connect with their communities.

Tik-Tocqueville

As America nears its 250th birthday, a sense of national pessimism contrasts with the country's objective successes, prompting a recommendation to reread Alexis de Tocqueville's "Democracy in America." Tocqueville, a young French aristocrat who visited in the 1830s, provided a prescient account of American democracy, capturing its unique mix of equality, prosperity, law, and religion. His observations on the seeming incomprehensibility of American domestic controversies, the feverish excitement of presidential elections, and the ubiquitous, manic energy of its people remain strikingly relevant. Tocqueville saw America's strange passions?commerce, religious fanaticism, restlessness?as integral to its democratic function, providing moral

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anchors and fostering compromise. He contrasted the dynamism of free states with the stagnation of slave states, though he was a racial pessimist. The book resonates with the Trump era, drawing parallels between Jacksonian populism and current political dynamics, highlighting Tocqueville's fundamental insight into American informality and "equality of conditions" as a way of relating to one another, rather than just choosing lawmakers. While he feared democratic unravelling into a new form of soft despotism, Tocqueville believed there was no going back from America's democratic future.

Lexington

Despite widespread economic gloom in the rich world, New York City is experiencing immense joy and excitement over the New York Knicks' journey to the NBA finals. The team's deep playoff run, after a 53-year championship drought, has united New Yorkers across political and social divides, with fans gathering in homes and public spaces to watch. The Knicks, celebrated for

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their decency, playfulness, and generosity, defy the stereotype of self-obsessed capitalists. Key players like Jalen Brunson and Josh Hart exemplify a team ethos focused on collective playmaking and sacrifice, as demonstrated by Brunson's decision to forgo a maximum salary to allow for other player signings. This "five-out" offense, combined with relentless defense, brought the Knicks a remarkable winning streak, including a historic comeback in game four of the finals. While this doesn't signal a socialist future for New York, the Knicks' style of play suggests a more enlightened capitalism aligned with enduring New Yorker qualities like pragmatism and fierce ambition, providing a much-needed boost to city morale, even as Donald Trump's presence at a game stirred typical New York grumbling.

ESSAY

From morning in America to endless

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conflict

The essay series "America at 250" traces significant historical periods and their lasting impacts. The 1980s saw Ronald Reagan usher in "morning again in America" with "Reaganomics," promoting market freedom and increased defense spending, ultimately contributing to the collapse of the Soviet Union. This era also saw the AIDS crisis expose and widen cultural cracks in American society, intensifying "culture wars." Reagan escalated the "war on drugs," which led to a vast expansion of the prison population and disproportionate incarceration of Black Americans. The 1980s also marked the rise of finance over industry, facilitated by globalization, leading to enormous wealth but also de-industrialization and growing income inequality, setting the stage for future backlashes.

The 1990s were characterized by Bill Clinton's "third way" politics, marked by fiscal discipline and welfare reform, but also by Newt Gingrich's relentless partisan

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attacks and the "politics of personal destruction," culminating in Clinton's impeachment. This period also saw the boom of the internet and tech stocks, driven by pioneers like Apple and Google, and the popularization of climate change concerns, which became a fiercely partisan issue.

The 2000 presidential election, decided by the Supreme Court, highlighted deep political polarization. This set the stage for the 9/11 attacks in 2001, which shattered America's sense of invulnerability and led to a global "war on terror," expanding surveillance powers and adopting a doctrine of pre-emptive action. The subsequent invasion of Iraq in 2003, based on false claims of WMDs, proved a disaster, eroding trust in government and America's moral standing, contributing to regional chaos and the rise of groups like Islamic State.

How the war on terror primed America for

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autocracy

The 9/11 attacks, while not an existential threat themselves, triggered an "overreaction" that initiated the decline of American global leadership and primed the nation for authoritarianism. The subsequent "forever war" in Afghanistan and Iraq, based on false pretenses, killed thousands, squandered global goodwill, and stained America's moral authority through torture and indefinite detentions. Despite President Obama rolling back some egregious policies, the targeted killings program expanded with little due process, demonstrating executive overreach. Domestically, the PATRIOT Act and subsequent expansions of surveillance transformed America into a nation defined by fear and mutual suspicion, with a quiescent Congress ceding power to the executive. This environment, coupled with rising Islamophobia, xenophobia, conspiracy theories, and political polarization, created the psychological and legal conditions ripe for an authoritarian takeover. The essay concludes that the road from 9/11 led directly to the

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January 6th Capitol riot, revealing that the gravest threat to American democracy came from within, through citizens goaded by an autocratic president to whom vast powers had been granted.

MIDDLE EAST & AFRICA

Iran has lost its fear of war

Iran has become emboldened and willing to risk low-level conflict, engaging in direct attacks against American and Israeli forces, including downing a helicopter and firing missiles. This marks a shift from decades of caution and reliance on proxies like Hizbullah, a change influenced by a new generation of leaders and the experience of a six-week war. Iran seeks to deter Israel and coerce Donald Trump into a more favorable peace deal, but its efforts have been mixed; it failed to deter Israeli strikes on Beirut, resulting in more

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damage to Iranian assets. The conflict highlights diverging interests between Trump, who seeks a deal, and Netanyahu, who wants to continue pressuring Hizbullah. While Iran has successfully used threats to secure a ceasefire from Trump, continued attacks risk resuming all-out war. The regime's confidence may also stem from desperation, as its limited capabilities mean a continued impasse could force it into difficult choices regarding escalation or allowing attrition of its proxies.

How Israel is frustrating Donald Trump's Iran plans

Binyamin Netanyahu, Israel's prime minister, has twice defied Donald Trump in recent days, complicating American efforts to broker a lasting truce with Iran. First, Israel attacked Hizbullah targets in Beirut, ignoring a limited ceasefire imposed by Trump, and then launched ballistic missiles at Iran in retaliation for Iranian missile fire towards northern Israel, again against Trump's instructions. These actions underscore Israel's

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determination to continue its campaign against Hizbullah and Iran's nuclear and missile programs, despite Trump's desire for a deal. Trump faces a dilemma: he has frozen Israel out of negotiations but is reluctant to break with his ally, despite growing public support for Palestinians in America. Israeli officials claim the two leaders remain close despite Trump's public rebukes. Netanyahu, facing an election, is under pressure to achieve decisive results in ongoing wars, which he has not, leaving him to pursue continued military action to prove his point. Ultimately, Israel's actions risk isolating it from its American ally, while demonstrating its ability to strike targets but not achieve strategic gains.

The first-ever robotic rescue at sea is a milestone

The recovery of two American Apache helicopter crew members downed by Iran near the Strait of Hormuz marks the first-ever drone rescue at sea. America's Central Command used an uncrewed surface vessel

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(USV) to recover the crew within two hours. This event signals a robotic revolution in casualty evacuation (CASEVAC), an area where Ukraine has already pioneered the use of air and ground drones for rescues in dangerous areas. A decade ago, Pentagon policy barred drones for rescue, but this has changed due to their advantages: USVs can assume more risk than crewed helicopters, are harder to spot, and avoid putting additional human lives in danger. However, challenges remain, including drones' limited visibility compared to planes and the need for robust AI or connectivity for casualty identification, as well as the physically demanding process for patients.

Syria is an unexpected beneficiary of the Gulf war

The closure of the Strait of Hormuz due to the Gulf war has made Syria an unlikely beneficiary, as Iraq seeks alternative routes for its oil exports. An 860km-long road from Ramadi, Iraq, to Syria's Baniyas terminal on the

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Mediterranean coast is now lined with lorries transporting oil, bypassing the blocked strait. Iraq, facing an 80% cut in oil production, has contracted firms to truck 650,000 tonnes of oil per month through Syria, which is a shorter route than alternatives. Despite Iraqi wariness of Ahmed al-Sharaa's new Syrian government, commercial interests have superseded sectarian mistrust, with Syrian Sunni militants providing escorts for Iraqi Shia lorry drivers. While current daily revenues for Syria are modest (\$1m-2m) and trucking has practical limits, the revived oil corridor could become crucial, potentially leading to new pipeline construction (costing at least \$4bn) and establishing Syria as an important transit hub on the world's energy map, drawing desperately needed foreign investment for its reconstruction.

Could Eritrea come in from the cold?

Eritrea, a reclusive dictatorship led by Isaias Afwerki, shunned by the West for decades and under U.S. sanctions since 2021, is showing signs of reconciliation

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with America. Reports of meetings with Donald Trump's adviser and Marco Rubio's talk of a "new era" suggest sanctions could be lifted, potentially to secure mining interests, help fight Houthis, or prevent a war between Eritrea and Ethiopia. Isaias's primary motivation is deterring Ethiopia's truculent Prime Minister Abiy Ahmed, who has threatened to invade for coastline access. To counter Abiy, Isaias has cultivated a regional network of allies including Egypt and the Tigray People's Liberation Front (TPLF). The U.S. is using both incentives (lifting sanctions, security deals with Ethiopia) and warnings to push for rapprochement between Eritrea and Ethiopia, aiming to avert a regional conflict that could merge with the Sudanese civil war. While Isaias appears open to talks if Eritrea's sovereignty is guaranteed, few trust Abiy's long-term intentions, and escalating tensions, as evidenced by recent Ethiopian bombings in Tigray, indicate that peace remains precarious.

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Fighting in Mogadishu risks making a weak state weaker

Mogadishu, Somalia's capital, has recently seen renewed heavy gunfire, signaling a return to instability after years of construction boom. The violence erupted because President Hassan Sheikh Mohamud refused to step down after his term expired, ramming through a constitutional overhaul to extend his term by a year, which the opposition views as an illegitimate power grab. This mirrors past "Villawood" soap operas of presidential term extensions, but the current standoff risks being more dangerous. Mohamud's reforms mandate one-person-one-vote elections, but the electoral commission is seen as under his control, leading a significant portion of the political class to boycott the vote. Both sides are reluctant to concede, and Western donors, losing leverage, have failed to broker a deal. Turkey's mediation efforts are viewed as partial to Mohamud, potentially encouraging confrontation. The political instability risks further fragmenting Somalia,

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potentially leading to parallel administrations and undermining efforts against the jihadist group al-Shabab.

THE AMERICAS

The World Cup will test Mexico's control over its territory

The World Cup in Guadalajara, Monterrey, and Mexico City will test Mexico's control over its territory amidst high violence and the influence of criminal groups. While gangs are unlikely to directly disrupt the tournament, security planners are preparing for a wide range of threats, including lone attackers, drones, and protests, alongside logistical challenges like airport capacity and traffic. The event, expected to add \$2.73bn to Mexico's economy and create jobs, offers a chance to improve its international image. However, Donald Trump's ongoing criticism of Mexico's anti-gang efforts

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and recent U.S. actions against Mexican officials pose a significant political risk. Any security or logistical issues during the matches could be leveraged by Trump to argue that Mexico cannot control its own territory, making this a crucial period for President Claudia Sheinbaum.

What happens when a presidential vote is a dead heat?

Peru's recent presidential run-off election between conservative Keiko Fujimori and left-wing Roberto Sánchez is too close to call, with Fujimori narrowly ahead by just 651 votes out of 18m. Neither candidate is popular; Fujimori is the daughter of an autocrat, and Sánchez wants to pardon former President Pedro Castillo, who attempted a coup. The election highlights Peruvians' struggle to choose the "least damaging" leader, with many casting blank ballots in the first round. If Fujimori wins, she will lack a strong mandate and congressional power for ambitious reforms, potentially

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facing immediate protests from the south. The country's political instability is a recurring theme, with three of the four tightest presidential elections in its history occurring in the last decade. Fujimori's persistence, having lost the last two by narrow margins, continues to force Peruvians to rehash old political debates. Sánchez accuses Fujimori of corruption and seeking impunity, while he defends Castillo's actions as "politically understandable." Recounts and legal battles could drag on for weeks, but Peruvians have grown accustomed to political uncertainty.

Techno-libertarians are flocking to the Caribbean

The Caribbean is becoming a hub for techno-libertarian enclaves, with projects like "Destiny" in Nevis aiming to create futuristic, independent zones with their own currencies and courts, sparking outrage among locals. These ventures, promoted by Western eccentrics and tech figures, seek to escape red tape and "woke" politics.

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Historically, similar attempts to establish new nations in the Caribbean have failed, but newer projects are more sophisticated, such as Próspera in Honduras, which uses a loose regulatory framework to attract fintech and biotech startups, even operating outside American regulatory purview for trials. While proponents argue these projects boost employment and offer competition to governments, critics highlight issues such as low tax contributions, exclusion of locals, and a perceived disregard for sovereignty, exemplified by Próspera suing Honduras for \$11bn after its authorization was deemed unconstitutional. The demand for such zones is rising due to pleasant weather, loose laws, dissatisfaction with traditional governance, and geopolitical events like the Iran war, leading to financial incentives being offered to locals.

ASIA

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An interview with South Korea's president

Lee Jae Myung, South Korea's new president, has projected calm and restored normality after the turbulence of his predecessor's martial law declaration and impeachment. A year into his term, Lee enjoys a high approval rating and is credited with political stability and navigating foreign relations deftly. His pragmatic approach to foreign policy, including stabilizing ties with China and forging a bond with Japan, is notable for a left-wing leader. Despite Donald Trump's past criticism, Lee's government has pledged increased defense spending and greater responsibility within the U.S. alliance, earning praise from American officials. Lee also secured Trump's blessing for South Korea to develop nuclear-powered submarines and enrich nuclear fuel, though he insists it's for peaceful purposes. However, challenges loom, including implementing these nuclear deals, North Korea's continued disinterest in talks, and domestic issues like equitable wealth distribution from the AI boom. Lee also

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faces ongoing political trials from his past, raising concerns about breaking the "curse of the Blue House" where many former presidents have faced legal troubles.

A chicken and egg problem

Asia's egg production has quadrupled in three decades, now accounting for almost two-thirds of global output, driven by soaring demand for cheap protein in developing countries like India and Indonesia. However, this growth largely relies on industrial battery cage farms, where hens live in tiny spaces, a practice banned in parts of Europe and America but common in Asia (89% of hens). Local consumers are unwilling to pay the higher costs of cage-free eggs, and governments prioritize productivity. To address animal welfare, the "cage-free credit" scheme, pioneered by Global Food Partners, allows companies unable to buy cage-free eggs to purchase credits that fund farmers transitioning to cageless systems. This initiative is gaining traction with major food firms. Technology offers further solutions,

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such as in-ovo sexing to prevent male chick culling, and plant-based egg substitutes like OnlyEg by Singaporean firm Float Foods, which caters to the growing vegan market.

Can India's cockroach party become a political movement?

Abhijeet Dipke, founder of the Cockroach Janta Party, unexpectedly found himself at the helm of a rapidly viral movement after a joke sparked by a Supreme Court justice's comment on jobless youth. Despite predictions of arrest, Dipke was granted permission to hold a rally in Delhi, which drew a few thousand young people protesting exam scandals, lack of jobs, and government unaccountability. The protesters, who chanted "We are cockroaches!" and wore cockroach masks, voiced deep-seated anger about the education system and suppression of dissent. Dipke has promised more rallies, tapping into widespread discontent with a powerful symbol. However, his movement currently lacks clear

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organization, a coherent message, and it's uncertain if he possesses the skills to transform this burst of anger into a sustainable political force. The government, initially attempting to suppress it, has since shifted to a more permissive stance, seemingly betting that the "cockroaches" will remain a minor pest.

Japan is rethinking its divorce laws

Japan, previously the only G7 country without joint custody after divorce, has introduced it with a civil code revision after nearly eight decades, reflecting a profound shift in thinking about family life. Traditionally, the custodial parent (usually the mother) could easily cut off contact with the other, leading to only one in three children seeing the absent parent, typically monthly. This "clean break" model often resulted in poor financial outcomes for single mothers and incentivized "parental abductions" by the spouse who took the children first. The new law aims to mandate joint decision-making on major issues and solidify parent-child contact, hoping to

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increase child support payments with a new statutory measure. Opposition from women's rights groups focuses on potential risks for victims of domestic violence. While it will take time to assess the law's practical impact, it marks a significant move towards ensuring children maintain relationships with both parents after divorce.

Money troubles are driving India's states to drink

Indian states have a conflicted relationship with alcohol, with constitutional calls for prohibition often clashing with the financial realities of liquor taxes. The introduction of a nationwide Goods and Services Tax (GST) in 2017 removed states' ability to set other taxes, exacerbating their indebtedness and making alcohol revenue existential. However, states must balance revenue generation with public health concerns and the popularity of prohibition among some groups. Karnataka has led the way with a rational alcohol policy, proposing

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a tax system based on alcohol content rather than type or brand, aiming to reduce social harm and boost revenue. This reform, if successful, could be copied by other Indian states, offering a sensible, remunerative, and politically feasible solution to their financial woes, marking a victory for common sense spurred by concentrated financial pressure and decades of hypocrisy.

CHINA

Nukes were off the agenda as Xi Jinping visited North Korea

Xi Jinping's second visit to North Korea, unlike his 2019 trip, did not focus on denuclearization but rather on counterbalancing growing Russian influence and reasserting China's role as Pyongyang's primary economic partner. Russia's military and financial aid to

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North Korea, in exchange for support in Ukraine, along with its explicit acceptance of North Korea's nuclear status, has shifted China's priorities. China is wary of North Korean aggression against South Korea and the potential for Japan and South Korea to develop their own nuclear weapons, but now believes it cannot force Kim Jong Un to renounce his program without risking economic collapse. North Korea's nuclear status is deemed "irreversible" by Kim's sister, and America's war in Iran has likely intensified Kim's determination to retain his arsenal. China is also keen to gain access to the Sea of Japan via North Korea and exploit tensions between South Korea and America. As U.S. President Trump has softened his stance on North Korea's nuclear status, the crucial question is what new offers he could make to bring Kim back to the negotiating table, given North Korea's strengthened bargaining position with Russian and Chinese backing.

China's notorious university-entrance

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exam is changing

China's gaokao, the national university-entrance exam, is undergoing significant transformations driven by declining test-taker numbers and the pervasive influence of artificial intelligence. Registrations for the gaokao have fallen for two consecutive years, a trend expected to accelerate due to plummeting birth rates and high youth unemployment, which is deterring some from pursuing higher education. Simultaneously, AI is reshaping education, with over 85% of students using AI for homework assistance through apps like Zuoyebang. While AI firms temporarily restrict chatbots during the gaokao, students use AI for university and subject selection. The government is actively integrating AI into classrooms, particularly in wealthier cities, to provide tailored instruction and overcome teacher shortages. However, concerns exist that AI might make traditional rote memorization outdated and diminish writing skills, while its impact on job markets for teachers, especially English instructors, is uncertain. The double pressure of

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demography and AI is expected to squeeze both teachers and tutors, though some believe AI could personalize learning in crowded classrooms.

In China ride-hailing work is a last resort for rural labourers

Shenzhen, a southern Chinese megacity, has officially declared its ride-hailing industry saturated, with over 140,000 cars and nearly 400,000 drivers averaging only 13.1 fares daily, far below subsistence levels. This saturation is driven by a struggling economy, which reduces demand for long rides, and an oversupply of drivers, as ride-hailing becomes a last-resort fallback for job seekers. Shenzhen's historical embrace of migrants makes it a top destination, leading to a flooded market, with many poor rural workers using their cars as temporary homes. Other Chinese megacities like Shanghai and Guangzhou face similar gluts, and Beijing restricts migrant influx. This trend signals a broader challenge for China's service industry and its ability to

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absorb migrants, even as the central government now aims to boost populations in big cities. Many migrants, disillusioned with their dreams of a better life, are returning to their poorer hometowns where living costs are lower, illustrating a worrying sign for China's economic future.

Chaguan

Geng Hongwei, a PhD dropout turned influencer known as "Classmate Geng," has triggered an earthquake in Chinese science by exposing academic fraud through technical videos. His revelations, detailing clumsy data fabrication by leading cancer researchers at top universities, have led to the removal of life-science deans and raised questions about the prevalence of fraud in Chinese research. Geng acts as an amplifier, making previously overlooked allegations go viral, forcing official investigations. His status as a dropout gives him freedom, and he has emboldened other scientists to speak out about China's high rate of academic misconduct,

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attributing it to systemic issues like publication quotas and cash bonuses tied to paper volume, which prioritize quantity over rigor. While the government initially supports Geng's role as a catalyst for change, his visibility has been curtailed, hinting at limits to official tolerance for public demands for accountability. This raises questions about whether science, which requires open data and external trust, can be controlled by the party in the same way citizen journalism was shut down years ago.

INTERNATIONAL

How to win the World Cup

Winning the World Cup is a rare feat, with only eight countries ever claiming the trophy, prompting an analysis of success factors beyond simple predictions. The Economist's model, based on Elo ratings and various

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national variables, found wealth, population, height, and geography explain about 70% of performance variation. South American and European teams have a significant historical advantage due to deep-rooted sporting cultures, intense competition, and higher investment in coaching and youth development, making footballing success largely self-perpetuating. However, countries like Japan have risen through strategic, bottom-up football development, contrasting with China's failed top-down approach. For poorer nations, importing talent through diasporas or naturalizing foreign players offers a faster route, with studies showing a correlation between ancestral diversity in squads and better results. This rise of migration in football infuriates racists but also links victories to more favorable attitudes towards immigration, making World Cup outcomes impactful beyond just bragging rights. Ultimately, the World Cup is more than a sporting event; it's a global festival of hope, drama, and communion, embodying the subversive idea that anything is possible.

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The World Cup has always been beset by scandal and strife

The World Cup has been plagued by scandal and strife since its inception, from suspicions of referee skulduggery benefiting host nations like Italy in 1934 and England in 1966, to allegations of player poisoning in later tournaments. Host countries are frequently accused of manipulating outcomes, and there have been instances of teams bolstering their rosters by abruptly granting citizenship to foreign players, a practice FIFA later restricted. Conspiracy theories, though unproven, highlight the intense global interest in the tournament. The World Cup generates billions in revenue for FIFA, which distributes funds to its member associations without clear rules, fostering an environment where corruption, as exposed in 2015 with over 40 officials charged, has thrived. Despite reforms under current president Gianni Infantino, the organization's reputation for cronyism persists, fueled by controversial hosting choices like Qatar. FIFA's uncanny ability to navigate

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geopolitical turbulence?allowing nations engaged in hostilities to compete?demonstrates its resilience in prioritizing the spectacle and its massive fortunes. With the tournament's expansion from 32 to 48 teams, the scope for conflict, grievance, and scandal is likely to increase, ensuring that while the goal is unity, widespread fury at the tournament's unfolding is a safer bet.

Why strongmen are wrong to loathe Europe

Strongmen like Donald Trump, Xi Jinping, and Vladimir Putin hold deep contempt for Europe, viewing its consensual politics and diverse societies as signs of weakness, yet this soft approach may prove valuable in an uncertain future. They exploit Europe's need for consensus to divide and rule, believing their power-centric approach is superior. However, the unpredictability of the future, driven by AI and other disruptive technologies, will test this might-makes-right philosophy. Europe's post-1945 embrace of rules-based,

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consensual politics, born from centuries of conflict, offers a model for navigating change without tyrannical majorities or the sudden ruin of individuals who fall out of favor. While strongmen prioritize efficiency and stability based on staying strong, they are also risk-takers, and their reliance on power rather than laws makes their systems vulnerable to unforeseen shifts in global strength. In contrast, Europe's commitment to coalition-building and individual rights could foster resilience and prevent panic when dividing lines between economic winners and losers inevitably shift.

BUSINESS

Fear of the SaaSpocalypse is tormenting techland

The Software-as-a-Service (SaaS) industry is facing an existential threat from artificial intelligence, dubbed the

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"SaaSocalypse," leading to a brutal sell-off in tech stocks. Investors fear that AI agents, becoming increasingly capable, will disrupt SaaS incumbents from four directions: large AI labs (like Anthropic and OpenAI) developing horizontal agents that integrate siloed SaaS products; AI-native startups (like Harvey and Serval) directly attacking specific business functions; enterprises increasingly building their own DIY software using AI; and SaaS companies' own efforts to incorporate AI, which cannibalizes existing revenue models. Traditional SaaS models, which charge per user "seat," are challenged by AI agents that don't require seats and cost more per usage for suppliers. While some SaaS sectors like cybersecurity and data management are thriving due to AI, others like Salesforce and Workday are seeing declining stock prices and grapple with revenue cannibalization as their new AI tools replace human workers and eat into legacy product sales.

The world's wealthy are migrating like

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never before

Record numbers of millionaires are migrating globally, driven by geopolitical uncertainty, low taxes, and personal security concerns, fueling a booming investment-migration industry. In 2025, over 140,000 millionaires migrated, with 165,000 expected this year, doubling the industry's turnover to \$40bn since 2019. Dubai was a favored destination for global south millionaires, but Westerners are increasingly seeking options, especially Britons after the pandemic and Europeans concerned about wealth taxes. America, despite its internal misgivings and ban on some countries' citizens, is now a primary market for outward migration, with many wealthy Americans seeking European residency due to political direction and travel flexibility. Concurrently, demand for America's EB-5 investment visa remains high among foreigners. New programs are emerging in places like St Vincent and the Grenadines, Uzbekistan, and Nauru. However, governments are under pressure to increase diligence in

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these programs, with some countries like Spain and Malta canceling or ruling against existing schemes, highlighting that while many countries are eager for rich immigrants, the welcome can sometimes turn cold due to regulatory scrutiny.

Robots could soon be delivering your pizza

Starship Technologies, an Estonian startup, is pioneering robot deliveries in Milton Keynes, England, and is on the verge of making its six-wheeled couriers cheaper than human delivery drivers. The company has spent 12 years developing robust hardware and AI models for its 35kg robots to navigate pavements safely and efficiently, facing similar challenges to robotaxis but with lower safety risks due to slower speeds. Starship's continuous improvements, including wireless charging and redundant computer systems, have significantly reduced human interventions per kilometer. With a current cost near £1 per delivery and a rapidly growing fleet (from 127 robots covering 116,000km in 2018 to 2,414 robots

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covering 5.2m km in 2025), these robots are poised to change cityscapes. While they may displace human drivers, the technology is advancing rapidly, even leading to instances where sympathetic Finns need to be dissuaded from "rescuing" stuck robots.

Apple's new Siri is a dark horse in the AI race

Apple is making a second attempt at AI with a "new Siri," shifting from building its own models to using Google's frontier AI, betting on its devices and personal data as the primary user portals. Its previous "Apple Intelligence" initiative, based on in-house models, was an embarrassing flop. Despite the earlier setbacks, Apple's stock has outperformed some AI rivals, as it has profited by taking a cut from chatbot apps on its devices. Apple holds two key advantages: extensive access to user data for Siri's functionalities across apps, and strong hardware and semiconductor prowess that allows many AI features to run on devices, reducing reliance on

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external servers. Apple is paying Google \$1bn annually, a fraction of in-house development costs, and could potentially switch underlying models in the future. However, the new features are still not fully ready for consumers, with limited availability in certain regions and languages, and investors remain cautious.

Another new boss aims to fix the world's biggest chocolate-maker

Barry Callebaut, the world's largest chocolate-maker, has appointed Hein Schumacher as its fourth CEO in six years, tasked with revitalizing the struggling firm. The Zurich-based company has faced years of soft sales, high debt, and melting share prices, exacerbated by soaring cocoa prices in 2023-24 due to climate change. Schumacher's turnaround plan aims for 2-4% annual sales volume growth, focusing on ten key growth markets like Brazil and Indonesia, and prioritizing the profitable Gourmet and speciality chocolate segments. Initial analyst reactions are mixed, with some seeing the

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plan as a crucial step, while others remain skeptical, predicting a slow recovery. The Jacobs family, major shareholders, recently sold a small portion of shares, which some interpret as a sign of slow recovery expectations. Schumacher's predecessor, Peter Feld, had a contentious plan to split the cocoa-processing unit from the chocolate-making business, which contributed to his departure. Challenges include economic and geopolitical uncertainty, potential future cocoa harvest issues, and the need to restore investor confidence.

Too many people are shockingly bad at prioritisation

Prioritization is a crucial skill, yet many individuals and organizations struggle with it, often motivated by achieving any goal rather than focusing on the most important ones. Research shows people tend to pursue multiple competing goals even when it's counterproductive, or prioritize small, achievable tasks over larger, more impactful ones, driven by a tangible

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sense of progress. Organizations often suffer from the "peanut-butter problem," spreading resources too thinly across too many priorities. Various frameworks exist to aid prioritization, such as the Eisenhower matrix (urgent/important) or the RICE scoring model (reach, impact, confidence, effort). Effective prioritization also requires clear communication within teams, as many executives often disagree on their company's strategic priorities. Crucially, prioritizing something new necessitates deprioritizing something old, with Amazon executives recommending explicit "kill criteria" for initiatives. The author concludes that effective prioritization involves choosing, communicating, and stopping.

American capitalism is run by millionaires, not billionaires

"The Everywhere Millionaire" by Owen Zidar and Eric Zwick reveals that American capitalism is significantly shaped by a vast network of private business owners,

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many of whom are millionaires (and some effectively billionaires), operating in often mundane industries. These entrepreneurs, like gutter sellers in Texas or toilet paper distributors in New Jersey, derive wealth from pass-through entities, benefiting from specific tax laws. Unlike high-profile tech billionaires who draw public ire, these private business owners often enjoy political privileges without public scrutiny, as seen with car dealerships or beer distributors. The book caters to those who believe the rich rig the system, but also to aspiring entrepreneurs, especially those in business schools interested in acquiring small, blue-collar firms. The authors' findings suggest that grit and business exposure are crucial for success, though these traits are not inheritable, leading to high failure rates for firms after the owner's death. Private equity funds often step in to acquire these businesses, acting as exit liquidity for entrepreneurs and contributing to constant capitalist reinvention.

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FINANCE & ECONOMICS

China is innovative. Its economy is a mess. Which matters more?

China's economy is a tale of two halves: rapid innovation in high-tech manufacturing coexisting with persistent issues like a property slump and local-government debt. Goldman Sachs predicts high-end manufacturing will contribute about one percentage point to annual GDP growth until 2029, but this will barely offset the two percentage point drag from the property sector's collapse. The economy, still recovering from pandemic lockdowns, faces producer-price deflation and reluctant consumers scarred by economic uncertainty. Unlike past growth models that generated widespread employment, the new tech-focused model is less labor-intensive and geographically concentrated, leaving many low-skilled workers behind. Local governments' vast debts, some reaching 43% of GDP, are unsustainable, particularly in

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poorer regions where costly public works fail to generate revenue. Despite central government support and tax breaks for "high-tech zones," many projects fail due to fierce competition, isolation from expertise, and a focus on subsidies over genuine profits, leading to a record high 32% of industrial firms operating at a loss. The article concludes that while Xi Jinping's bet on tech dominance is a high-stakes gamble, it may not be enough to lift Chinese spirits or solve its persistent economic problems.

How big are China's emerging industries?

Economists are struggling to measure the size and impact of China's emerging "new productive forces" as the economy shifts away from property towards high-tech manufacturing. A Rhodium Group analysis, using China's National Bureau of Statistics data from 2023, estimates that new-energy vehicles (NEVs), batteries, and renewable energy (the "new three") accounted for only 3.8% of GDP, while property-related

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demand was over 16%. Even when adding investment in new electricity infrastructure, robotics, software, and AI, the total only reached 6.3% of GDP in 2025. Goldman Sachs' broader measure of high-tech manufacturing, including electronics and medical products, accounts for about 8% of GDP, still smaller than property and less labor-intensive. While high-tech manufacturing is growing rapidly, potentially offsetting property's drag on growth by next year, it won't be enough to achieve Xi Jinping's 4.5-5% annual GDP growth target alone. To meet official growth goals, the "new productive forces" must extend beyond headline industries, applying new ideas across existing businesses, which the NBS's broader definition already suggests accounts for 18% of GDP.

Stears wants to be Africa's Bloomberg terminal

Stears, a Nigerian company, aims to become Africa's equivalent of a Bloomberg terminal, providing

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high-quality financial analysis and data in a continent where such information is notoriously hard to access. Founded by Nigerian students in London, Stears initially blended news and data but pivoted to focus on financial information after struggling with subscriber growth for its media operation. The company's analysts undertake extensive legwork, from cultivating sources at stock exchanges to reverse-engineering government websites and even becoming citizens to access official data. This granular data, much of it gathered for bespoke projects for clients like the European Bank for Reconstruction and Development, feeds its digital platform, which saw a fivefold increase in data added last year. Stears' dollar revenue doubled in 2025, with foreign business now comprising 70% of its total license fees, appealing to international investors despite its lower pricing compared to Western rivals. With Western platforms showing little interest in Africa, Stears aims to become indispensable as the continent's financial markets mature.

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A bidding war erupts for the world's oldest bank

Monte dei Paschi di Siena (MPS), the world's oldest surviving bank, has become the center of a bidding war in Italian finance. Following its €16bn takeover of Mediobanca last September, which involved internal board drama, Banco BPM, Italy's fourth-largest lender, proposed a €50bn merger with MPS. The very next day, Intesa Sanpaolo, Italy's largest bank, launched a higher, rival bid of €31bn for MPS, aiming to create a European banking colossus worth around €130bn. Intesa's offer includes newly issued shares and a cash premium for MPS owners, and it plans to shed half of MPS's branches to BPER, creating Italy's third-largest banking group, to appease trustbusters. Italy's conservative government is expected to favor Intesa's bid over BPM's, which has a 20% stake held by French bank Crédit Agricole, reflecting a preference for domestic financial control.

The world's strategic oil reserves are

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running out fast

More than 100 days into the third Gulf war, oil markets have remained placid despite renewed hostilities, largely due to demand reduction and the tapping of strategic petroleum reserves (SPRs). The 32 members of the International Energy Agency pledged to release 400m barrels, almost half of which have been delivered at a record pace. However, this pace is expected to slow significantly. Japan, initially a major proponent of coordinated releases and drawing heavily from its SPR, is now reluctant to authorize further large drawdowns due to comfort levels and rising competition for alternative sources. America's SPR, nearly half-depleted from previous drawdowns, has hit its lowest levels since the 1980s, facing physical constraints on pumping and statutory limits, meaning its deliveries are also expected to slow. Europe, which initially pushed back on joint action and holds most of its reserves in commercial tanks, has effectively free-ridden on others' SPRs. As holiday fuel demand rises and American exports weaken,

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Europe will need to plug the shortfall, but its ability to release emergency barrels at scale is unproven. With commercial stocks projected to hit minimum operational levels by September, the depletion of global reserves could lead to higher oil prices and prolonged instability, as replenishment will be needed after the war ends.

Wall Street?s undignified SpaceX mania

Wall Street is displaying undignified "ick" behavior in its desperate efforts to court Elon Musk and secure a role in the upcoming SpaceX IPO, scheduled for June 12th. Firms like Fidelity are lowering minimum account balances for small investors, while Nasdaq and FTSE Russell plan to fast-track SpaceX into their indices. Investment bankers are going to extreme lengths, adorning lobbies with rocket imagery and hosting chummy interviews with Musk, despite his past feuds. Their financial projections for SpaceX's xAI division and overall sales are astronomically optimistic. Bankers are willing to accept paltry fees (0.75% of proceeds)

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compared to historical IPO averages, because the sheer size of the deal means significant earnings. SpaceX has neutered its bankers by reserving up to 30% of the offering for retail investors and setting a fixed share price, reducing their power. This marks a shift from past IPO waves where bankers held immense influence. If SpaceX's debut flops, banks face scrutiny despite limited control, but even success highlights their diminished importance in the current financial landscape, characterized by companies staying private longer and alternative trading firms.

How to share AI riches

The artificial intelligence boom has generated immense wealth for a few, sparking a populist push from figures like Donald Trump and Bernie Sanders for wider public sharing of AI riches. Proposals range from voluntary equity contributions to public wealth funds (championed by OpenAI's Sam Altman and Trump) to a one-off 50% stock tax on AI firms (Sanders), reflecting a growing

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belief in redistributing AI's gains. This idea is serious given America's concentrated wealth and the potential for AI to further shift returns from labor to capital. However, practical questions arise: voluntary donations face challenges of dilution and lack of founder equity for some AI leaders. Mandatory transfers, like Sanders's proposal, risk being seen as expropriation, chilling investment. Even if schemes are implemented, initial payouts would be modest (a few hundred dollars per American annually), insufficient for universal basic income. Public ownership carries risks, blurring lines between regulation and shareholder interests, potentially entrenching incumbents and distorting competition. The article suggests a public wealth fund invested in a broad equity index, funded by AI profits or mandatory contributions, as a way to minimize downsides and provide a modest, long-term dividend.

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SCIENCE & TECHNOLOGY

How artificial intelligence got better at building itself

Anthropic's chatbot, Claude, has become indispensable for coders, with over four-fifths of Anthropic's own code now written by its AI. The quality and quantity of AI output have dramatically improved, leading Anthropic's co-founder, Jack Clark, to predict a 60% chance of an AI system creating its own successor without human involvement by the end of 2028. This process, known as "recursive self-improvement" (RSI), would create a closed loop of accelerating AI development, with unknown but potentially profound consequences. RSI requires automating various specialist tasks in AI development, from theory and coding to data sourcing and safety checks, with some tasks proving more amenable to AI assistance than others. The AI-powered acceleration of research and development could lead to

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exponential productivity boosts. While no AI can yet build its own successor entirely, large models can build smaller ones and, with human help, contribute significantly to building other large models. Andrej Karpathy's work on Nanochat demonstrates AI's ability to significantly speed up training processes, highlighting human limitations. The shrinking human role in AI production raises concerns about loss of control and the potential for superintelligence to become uncontrollable, leading to dystopian outcomes. However, physical constraints like access to computing power and high-quality training data still impose limits on the speed of self-improvement.

New techniques can predict and prevent lung cancer

New research has identified a molecular signature that can predict a higher risk of lung cancer, paving the way for preventive treatments. An international team analyzed blood samples from nearly 50,000 people and

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found a group of 14 proteins whose levels increased five years or more before a lung cancer diagnosis. This 14-protein "signature" was confirmed across eight other global data sets. The scientists discovered that these proteins are elevated when an inflammatory pathway, linked to lung cancer and triggered by air pollution, is activated. Crucially, blocking a key molecule in this pathway (interleukin-1 beta) prevented tumors from forming in mice. Existing anti-inflammatory drugs that block IL-1 β , used to treat auto-inflammatory conditions, were found to nearly halve the risk of lung cancer in people with high levels of the 14-protein signature. The next steps involve developing a commercial blood test for this signature and investigating other anti-inflammatory drugs, marking a significant step towards cancer prevention.

Too much Chinese science is ignored by the West

Chinese scientific research, despite its massive output

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and leading position in respected journals, is largely overlooked by Western researchers, according to two recent analyses. One working paper found that only about one-third of citations of Chinese papers came from outside China, compared to around half for the US and EU. Another analysis showed that while Western researchers are increasingly citing Chinese work, it's still less than expected, with a striking imbalance where Chinese researchers cite American work more than expected, but the reverse is not true. This oversight might be partly due to Chinese researchers extensively citing each other's work, a concentration of Chinese research in fields where local researchers lead, and a lack of trust due to a higher retraction rate for Chinese papers. Cultural ignorance, such as unfamiliarity with Chinese institutional hierarchies, also plays a role. The decline in international collaborations on Chinese papers, partly due to geopolitical tensions, exacerbates the problem. This oversight means valuable work is missed, slowing the spread of ideas and breakthroughs, a cost that will

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grow as China continues to be a major source of new knowledge.

The chemicals that reduce wrinkles

Many wrinkle-reducing products claim to reverse aging, but only a handful of ingredients have strong scientific backing. Skin aging is caused by time and environmental damage from UV light, pollution, and smoking, which harm collagen and elastin fibers. Tretinoin, a prescription-only derivative of vitamin A, is the most scientifically supported ingredient. Originally for acne, it thickens the epidermis and stimulates collagen production, partially restoring the extracellular matrix and reducing wrinkles. Milder, over-the-counter retinoids like retinol and retinal convert to tretinoin in the skin and are also effective, though irritation is possible. Vitamin C (ascorbic acid), a crucial antioxidant, supports collagen production and can reduce wrinkles and hyperpigmentation, but its instability requires careful formulation and storage. Peptides,

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another common ingredient, encourage or prevent the breakdown of extracellular matrix proteins, or relax face muscles, though studies supporting their anti-wrinkle benefits are often company-funded. While these ingredients can partially reverse aging signs, dermatologists emphasize that prevention, particularly sun protection, is more effective.

CULTURE

Who should win the World Cup?

The World Cup transcends mere sport, serving as a secular rapture for players, fans, and nations, embodying international relations, soft diplomacy, and a collective celebration of hope. Beyond predicting the winner, asking "who should win?" reveals the tournament's deeper purpose: creating memories, offering a distraction from daily woes, and symbolizing redemption or the

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triumph of underdogs. For the upcoming competition, the article suggests discarding traditional favorites (the eight past winners) to create a more exciting and fair thought experiment. Among the remaining candidates, plucky small countries with talent, like the Netherlands or Croatia, are contenders, but Portugal, with its long wait and deep footballing obsession, is deemed most deserving. Among larger, football-loving nations that have never won, Japan is noted for its strategic football development, and African contenders like Senegal are highlighted for their unifying power amid political strife. Ultimately, Latin America is identified as where a first-time victory would bring the greatest happiness, with Mexico, a soccer-mad country facing numerous hardships and criticisms from Donald Trump, being the most deserving, creating a poetic scenario if it were to beat Portugal in the final.

The most hated countries at the FIFA World Cup

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National anthems, often rooted in historical conflicts, provide a unique lens into national animosities, especially when performed at the World Cup. Analyzing the translated lyrics of all competing countries' anthems using AI tools, The Economist found that Spain is the "most hated" country, explicitly mentioned as an enemy in three anthems, largely from its former colonies which gained independence through revolutionary wars. Beyond explicit mentions, historical context reveals that at least nine more anthems allude to other countries, with Britain being referenced in America's anthem. National anthems are a macabre genre, with all but eight World Cup countries making violent references. Portugal's anthem is unusually bellicose, with 11 violence references per 100 words, calling citizens "to arms" 12 times. In contrast, some notorious historical invaders like Britain, Germany, and Japan have remarkably peaceful anthems. The World Cup provides a platform where hard-fought football contests, rather than historical conflicts, settle rivalries, allowing fans to largely

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overlook the combative lyrics before matches.

Steven Spielberg has more to say about aliens

Steven Spielberg's new film, "Disclosure Day," returns to his recurring alien themes of distrust in government, misunderstanding by loved ones, and the search for home, but adds a cosmic plea for peace. The complex plot follows a cyber-security renegade, Daniel, and his girlfriend Jane, on the run from a sinister agency, as he plans to leak records of alien contacts dating back to Roswell. Meanwhile, a TV meteorologist, Margaret, gains telepathic abilities after an eerie bird encounter, leading her to speak Russian and Korean. The film features familiar Spielberg motifs: knowledge as sacred yet dangerous, John Williams's swelling music, and moments of quiet tenderness punctuated by gags. Like "Close Encounters of the Third Kind," it's a parable of communication and forging connections in a disbelieving world, where contact with aliens represents

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human struggles. While the film offers stunts, humor, and memorable shots, its ultimate message is that aliens might forestall nuclear conflict by putting human squabbles into intergalactic perspective. However, the author finds that the film's climax, with the physical appearance of the wise, fragile extraterrestrials, is an unnecessary addition to an already rich narrative.

Saint or sinner: Antoni Gaudí's polarising style

Antoni Gaudí, a century after his death, remains a polarizing but globally iconic architect, synonymous with Barcelona, most notably through his unfinished basilica, the Sagrada Família. This massive structure, nearing completion after almost 150 years, recently became the world's tallest church and attracts nearly 5m visitors annually. Gaudí, born to coppersmiths, was a self-taught engineer and both a reactionary and revolutionary, rejecting straight lines in nature and incorporating organic forms, curves, and representations

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of plants and animals into his technically innovative buildings. His work, deeply influenced by Catholicism and Catalan nationalism, aimed to express his faith. After his death in 1926, the Sagrada Família was initially neglected and even vandalized during the Spanish civil war, with critics like George Orwell deeming it hideous. However, Surrealists, the 1960s counterculture, and Japanese tourists later championed his legacy, and renewed funding in the 1980s accelerated construction. While admired by architects like Le Corbusier for his structural mastery, Gaudí's aesthetic remains divisive, often seen as kitsch, yet celebrated for its iconoclastic color and grandeur, placing him on the path to sainthood.

The people behind the largest art heist in history

Matthew Campbell's new book, "The Man Who Stole the Gods," details what he calls "the world's biggest art heist," led by British businessman Douglas Latchford, who orchestrated the plundering of thousands of Khmer

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antiquities from Cambodia's temples. Latchford, obsessed with the Khmer empire, opened a gallery in Bangkok in 1974, supplying stolen masterpieces to prominent collectors and institutions like the Metropolitan Museum of Art. The book vividly describes the murky supply chain: desperate Cambodian looters, using destructive methods, would plunder to order, transporting pieces to brokers who then moved them across the border to Latchford. He would then invent provenances and forge documents for buyers who largely ignored the illicit origins of the artworks. Despite Latchford dying before facing justice, American investigators successfully returned many artifacts to Cambodia. While Campbell suggests the investigation may have ended the US market for such looted objects, the article concludes this is unrealistic, as the desire for beautiful antiquities and the lucrative illicit trade will likely persist.

What ?Backrooms? and ?Obsession?

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reveal about Gen Z's fears

Two recent horror films, "Obsession" and "Backrooms," made by young YouTubers on minuscule budgets, have achieved massive box office success, resonating particularly with Gen Z audiences. "Obsession" (Curry Barker) and "Backrooms" (Kane Parsons) tap into common Gen Z fears and fixations, including profound loneliness, with protagonists who are isolated and unhappy. Both films explore themes of instability, updating traditional tropes like the haunted house for a generation facing precarious living situations and fearing they may never own a home. Another shared theme is dismal prospects and thwarted ambition, with characters who are failed or unfulfilled. The movies also depict acts of self-destruction, reflecting a sense of hopelessness that many Gen Zers report feeling. The creators' success, however, suggests a bright future for these young filmmakers despite the bleakness of their cinematic worlds.

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ECONOMIC & FINANCIAL INDICATORS

Economic data, commodities and markets

No significant coverage this issue.

OBITUARY

Marjane Satrapi set out to correct the West's views of Iran

Marjane Satrapi, author of the graphic novel "Persepolis," died on June 4th, aged 56, leaving a legacy of correcting Western views of Iran through her personal narrative. Her work, starting with her childhood experiences during Iran's 1979 Islamic Revolution, chronicled her outrage against compulsory veiling and repression, her double life in mullah-ruled Iran, and her struggles with identity and assimilation while living in Europe. Satrapi's simple yet emotionally profound

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drawings conveyed complex emotions and harrowing moments, such as the devastation of war. After the success of "Persepolis" and its Oscar-nominated animated adaptation, she continued to address the repression of women, notably in "Woman, Life, Freedom." Satrapi sought to explain Iran to the West, challenging the simplistic narrative of "veil and beard and nuclear weapon" and highlighting the rich history and modern resistance of ordinary Iranians. Despite becoming a French citizen, Iran remained her spiritual home, and her work aimed to bridge the gap between her two worlds, believing that freedom would ultimately prevail.